The Human Capabilities Driving AI Transformation

AI transformation is, at its core, a **people and culture project** — not a tooling project. Leaders carry long-held beliefs that effort equals value, so when AI makes work feel easy, it triggers guilt as much as excitement. Real discomfort exists around identity, pride, and standards in creative businesses.

This means AI training cannot just be feature demos. It must work at the level of language, habits, and psychology — building the human skills and mindsets that make AI a genuine amplifier of people.

SKILL 1

Briefing: Prompting as Structured Thinking

The 10/80/10 Principle

Invest **10%** crafting a precise prompt, **80%** delivering against it, and **10%** reviewing whether outputs truly match it.

Good Prompting = Good Briefing

Prompting is just good briefing in a new medium. AI rewards structured, specific thinking far more than vague instructions — the discipline of a great brief translates directly.

SKILL 2

Questioning: The Scarce Skill in an Age of Answers

With the shift from Search Engines to Answer Engines, the scarce skill is **asking better questions** — not finding more answers. Seniors get more from AI because they probe, reframe, and challenge outputs instead of treating the first response as truth.

Probe

Push past the first response to uncover deeper, more accurate outputs.

Reframe

Approach the same problem from a different angle to unlock better answers.

Challenge

Never accept AI output as truth — interrogate assumptions and test conclusions.

SKILL 3

Taste & References: Spotting the One That's Right

AI throws up endless **"okay" options**. Taste is the ability to spot the one that's truly right. The good news: taste becomes trainable when you build shared reference libraries, look-books, and style vocabularies that *name what used to be purely intuitive*.

Reference Libraries

Shared collections of exemplary work

Look-Books

Visual vocabularies for creative standards

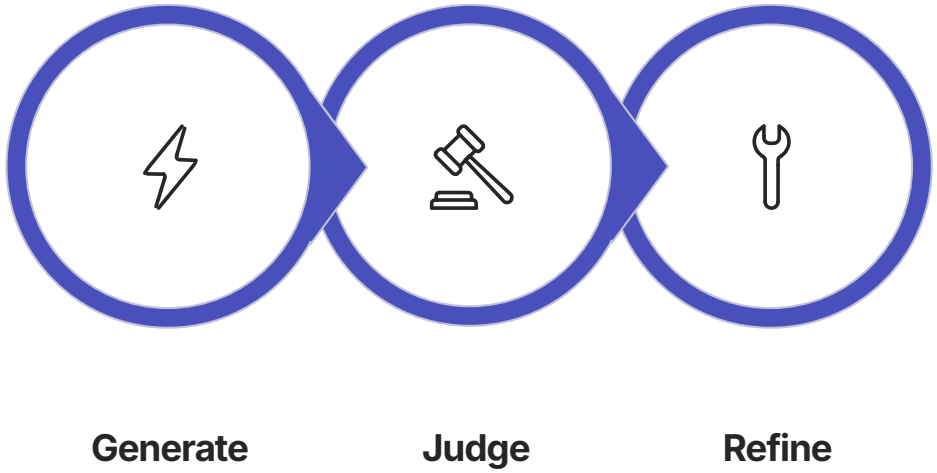
Style Guides

Named criteria for what "right" looks like

SKILL 4

Iteration: Generate, Judge, Refine

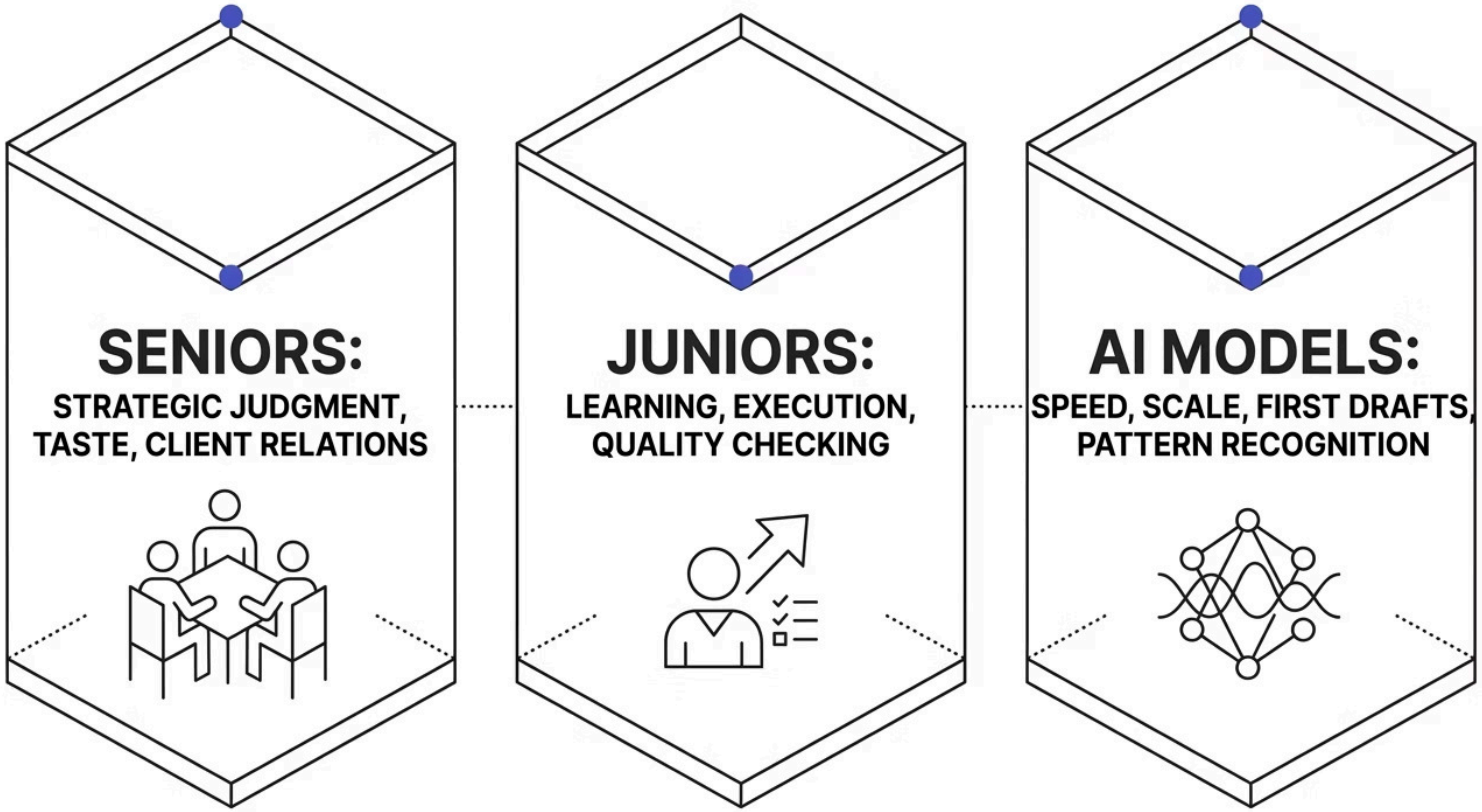
Great AI work doesn't appear fully formed — it's built through **fast cycles of generate–judge–refine**. The mindset shift is from trying to get it right first time to expecting multiple, cheap iterations until the idea is sharp enough to ship.



SKILL 5

Allocation: Deciding Who Does What

Value now comes from how you **allocate intelligence** across humans, AI tools, and systems. Winners will deliberately decide what seniors, juniors, and models each do best — instead of drifting into a world of overworked AI super-users and underused juniors.



SKILL 6

Composition: Assembling the Meal

AI Gives You Ingredients

Humans still create the meal. AI produces raw components — visuals, data, copy — but cannot assemble them into a coherent whole.

Storymaking

The real skill is assembling AI outputs into clear **stories and decks** where insight and data, creative and brand land as one coherent, persuasive narrative.

SKILL 7

Integrity: AI Has No Conscience — You Do

As IP, data, and "AI slop" risks grow, agencies need **clear red lines** on where AI is allowed, how outputs are checked, and who owns accountability — applying the Washington Post test to work that can now be produced at scale.

Where AI Is Allowed

Define clear boundaries for appropriate AI use across the business.

How Outputs Are Checked

Establish robust review processes before anything ships at scale.

Who Owns Accountability

Assign clear ownership so responsibility never disappears into the model.

SKILL 8

Leadership & Change Readiness

Change only sticks when leaders **set a clear vision for AI, model the behaviours they want, and protect time, investment, and ownership** so people can actually adapt — rather than asking teams to bolt AI on top of an unchanged, already overloaded system.

All 8 Human Skills at a Glance

AI transformation succeeds when these eight human capabilities are developed alongside the tools.

01

Briefing

Prompting as structured, precise thinking using the 10/80/10 principle.

02

Questioning

Probing and reframing outputs rather than accepting the first response.

03

Taste & References

Spotting the right option from endless "okay" outputs using shared vocabularies.

04

Iteration

Fast generate–judge–refine cycles until the idea is sharp enough to ship.

05

Allocation

Deliberately deciding what seniors, juniors, and models each do best.

06

Composition

Assembling AI ingredients into coherent, persuasive three-beat narratives.

07

Integrity

Maintaining clear red lines on IP, data, and accountability at scale.

08

Leadership

Setting vision, modelling behaviours, and protecting space for real change.